HIRING PLAYBOOK

Hiring is an experience problem: the handbook

Eleven worksheets, handbooks and playbooks for redefining a design hiring experience, including how to design the on-site assignment, define the signals and ask candidates how it felt.

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Hiring Experience Alignment Worksheet

Define a hiring experience that fits your organisation, before you design any part of it.

How to use it. Fill this in first, ideally with your HR partner in the room. It becomes the brief every other worksheet refers back to.

1. Context

Roles we expect to hire this year
Role, level, how many, by when

Who is involved in a hire today
Hiring manager, recruiter, HR partner, interviewers, approvers

Tools we already have
Applicant system, calendars, job boards, feedback forms, reporting

What is working, and what is not
Be specific. A recent hire is a good example.

2. What must be true

Pick the three to five promises that matter most. These become your tests whenever a process step is debated.

- [ ] Every candidate always knows what happens next and when
- [ ] Decisions rest on evidence, not impressions
- [ ] The process respects the candidate's time
- [ ] We say honestly what working here is like
- [ ] Every candidate gets a reply, whatever the outcome
- [ ] Interviewers are briefed and prepared before every conversation
- [ ] Everyone is asked comparable questions for the same role
- [ ] New joiners feel expected from the day they accept

Our own promises (write your own)

3. Constraints we work within

Policy and legal
Approvals, data, feedback rules

Time and budget
Headcount, channels, tooling

People and capacity
Interviewer time, recruiter load

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4. The hiring stages, and what we promise at each

STAGE	WHO OWNS IT	TOOL OR CHANNEL	PROMISE TO THE CANDIDATE	TIME LIMIT
Attract				
Apply				
Screen				
Portfolio conversation				
Craft exercise				
Team conversations				
Decision				
Offer				
Close the loop				
Onboard				

5. Gaps, and the first three changes

GAP WE FOUND	CHANGE WE WILL MAKE	OWNER	BY WHEN

6. Agreed with HR

What HR owns, what the design team owns, and how we review this together

> Review this worksheet after your first completed hire. What you learned from that hire is worth more than anything you planned up front.

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WORKSHEET · PART 1 · MANAGING THE HIRING EXPERIENCE

Role Definition Worksheet

Turn a vague need into a clear role and a job description people want to answer.

How to use it. Work through sections 1 to 4 first. Only then write the job description in section 5.

1. Why this role exists

The problem this person will solve
What is not happening today that should be?

What success looks like after twelve months
Three outcomes, written as things that will be true

2. Level and scope

DIMENSION	WHAT WE EXPECT IN THIS ROLE
Level	
Scope of ownership	
Decisions they make alone	
Decisions they influence	
People or partners they work with	
Reports to	

3. Must have, can learn, not needed

Must have on day one
Keep this short

Can learn here
What we will teach

Not needed
What we tend to ask for out of habit

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4. What we can honestly offer

The work, the people, the growth, and the trade-offs

5. The job description

Write it in this order. Plain language, no internal jargon, and no list longer than five lines.

Title and team
Use a title people search for

Why this role exists
Two or three sentences from section 1

What you will do
Up to five outcomes, not tasks

What you bring
Only the must-haves from section 3

What you will learn and who you will work with
Section 4, written to the candidate

How we hire
The stages and the time each takes, so nobody has to guess

6. Check the wording

- [ ] A strong candidate would recognise themselves in the “what you bring” list without feeling they must tick every box
- [ ] No requirement is there only because the last person had it
- [ ] No wording suggests a particular age, background or personality
- [ ] Compensation and location are stated, or the reason they are not is explained
- [ ] Someone outside the team can read it and explain what the job is

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WORKSHEET · PART 1 · MANAGING THE HIRING EXPERIENCE

Employer Story and Outreach Worksheet

Say what working in your team is really like, and decide where and how people will hear it.

How to use it. Do the story first, then the plan. Good designers read a team for signs of craft and honesty before they ever apply.

1. The team story

What we make and who it is for
In plain words

How we work together
Rituals, reviews, how disagreement is handled

What we value
Shown by what we do, not by adjectives

What is hard here, said honestly
Candidates trust teams that say this

2. Proof a candidate can see

- [ ] Shipped work we can talk about in public
- [ ] How we hire, written down and published
- [ ] A visible design system or craft standard
- [ ] A talk, article or case study from the team
- [ ] Team members willing to speak to candidates
- [ ] Stories of people growing in the team

What we have today, and what is missing

3. Activities that help hiring

Tick two or three you can sustain for six months. A small thing done regularly beats a big thing done once.

- [ ] Open portfolio review hours
- [ ] A referral kit for team members
- [ ] Team spotlight posts
- [ ] Open office hours for people thinking of applying
- [ ] A design talk or meetup hosted by the team
- [ ] A “how we hire” page on the careers site
- [ ] Campus or community sessions
- [ ] Writing about the work we do

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4. Channel plan

CHANNEL	WHAT WE WILL DO THERE	OWNER	HOW OFTEN	HOW WE WILL KNOW IT WORKS

5. One line for the job post

The sentence that tells a candidate why this team is worth their time

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WORKSHEET · PART 1 · MANAGING THE HIRING EXPERIENCE

HR Partnership Worksheet

Agree how you and HR will run hiring together, and how you will keep improving it.

How to use it. Use this in your first working session with HR. Write down what you agree, then keep the page.

1. Get comfortable with the tools

Before you ask HR to change anything, learn how the system works from the inside. Tick each item when you have done it yourself.

- [ ] Walked a role through the system from requisition to posting
- [ ] Seen the application as the candidate sees it, on a phone too
- [ ] Seen the pipeline as the recruiter sees it
- [ ] Filled in and submitted interview feedback as an interviewer
- [ ] Found where reports live and which numbers it can give
- [ ] Know what the system cannot do, so I do not design around it

2. Who does what

ACTIVITY	HIRING MANAGER	RECRUITER OR HR	INTERVIEWERS	DECISION BY
Requisition and approval				
Job description				
Posting and outreach				
Screening				
Scheduling				
Interview feedback				
Decision and offer				
Candidate updates				
Onboarding handover				

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3. How we will work

Regular check-in
Who, how often, what we look at

Response times we agree to
For example candidate updates, feedback, scheduling

How we escalate a stuck hire
Who, and after how long

What we try first as a small pilot
One role, one change, a review date

4. What we measure together

MEASURE	WHERE IT COMES FROM	TODAY	TARGET
Time in each stage			
Time to reply to a candidate			
Interviewer feedback on time			
Offers accepted			
Candidate feedback on the process			
Hiring manager satisfaction			

5. Review

What we learned from the last hire, and what we change

> Bring evidence, not opinions. A candidate's own words about the process do more to move a system than any slide.

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WORKSHEET · PART 2 · THE CANDIDATE HIRING EXPERIENCE

Candidate Journey Map Worksheet

Map the whole process from three sides at once: the candidate, the interviewer and the decision.

How to use it. Print it large, or copy the grid onto a whiteboard. Do it with a recent hire's real timeline in front of you.

1. The journey, stage by stage

	ATTRACT AND APPLY	SCREEN	PORTFOLIO CONVERSATION	CRAFT EXERCISE	TEAM CONVERSATIONS	DECISION AND OFFER	CLOSE OR ONBOARD
Candidate does and feels							
Candidate needs to know							
Interviewer does							
Interviewer needs							
Recruiter or HR does							
Hiring manager does							
We promise (and by when)							

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2. Moments that matter

Circle the three moments where a candidate is most likely to feel lost, ignored or uncertain. Then decide what we send or do at each.

MOMENT	WHAT GOES WRONG TODAY	WHAT WE WILL SEND OR DO	OWNER

3. Messages the candidate receives

WHEN	WHAT IT SAYS	SENT BY	WITHIN
Application received			
Moving to screening			
Before each interview			
After each interview			
Decision			
Offer or closing			

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Interview and Evaluation Handbook

Brief interviewers, ask comparable questions, score against evidence and decide with a written reason.

How to use it. Give the first two pages to every interviewer before they meet a candidate. Use the rest to run the decision.

1. Principles

- [ ] Every interviewer knows the role, the competency they own and what a strong answer sounds like
- [ ] Interviewers write notes from what was said and shown, and keep opinions separate
- [ ] Everyone scores on their own before anyone discusses
- [ ] The same competencies are assessed the same way for every candidate for a role
- [ ] We decide on evidence of what the person can do in this role, not on pedigree or comfort

2. Interviewer briefing checklist

- [ ] I have read the role definition and the candidate's portfolio or resume
- [ ] I know which competency I own and the questions I will use
- [ ] I know what the candidate has been told about this conversation
- [ ] I have blocked time to write feedback within 24 hours
- [ ] I will not read other interviewers' feedback until I have submitted mine

3. Competencies and what each rating means

COMPETENCY	1 NOT YET	2 DEVELOPING	3 MEETS THE BAR	4 RAISES THE BAR
Craft and quality of work				
Problem framing and systems thinking				
Collaboration and communication				
Ownership and leadership for the level				
Learning and self-awareness				

Write a short anchor in each cell for your role and level before the first interview. Without anchors, ratings drift.

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4. Questions to start from

COMPETENCY	ASK	LISTEN FOR
Craft	Walk me through a piece of work you are proud of. What did you decide, and why?	Specific decisions, trade-offs, what they would change
Problem framing	Tell me about a time the brief turned out to be the wrong problem.	How they questioned it, who they involved, what changed
Collaboration	Describe a disagreement with a product or engineering partner. How did it end?	Respect, evidence used, what they learned
Ownership	What is something you improved that nobody asked you to?	Initiative, follow-through, impact beyond the task
Learning	What did you get wrong in the last year, and what did you do about it?	Honest account, changed behaviour

5. Notes that help the decision

What I saw and heard
Quotes and examples

What I am unsure about
What would I need to see?

My rating and why
Competency, 1 to 4, one reason

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6. The debrief

- [ ] Everyone has submitted feedback before the meeting starts
- [ ] We go competency by competency, starting with the least certain
- [ ] Each person states evidence first, then their rating
- [ ] We name the risks and how we could reduce them
- [ ] The hiring manager decides, and writes down the reason

7. Decision record

COMPETENCY	RATINGS	STRONGEST EVIDENCE	CONCERN
Craft			
Problem framing			
Collaboration			
Ownership			
Learning			

Decision, level and the reason in one paragraph

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Decisions and Candidate Care Playbook

Make the offer well, and close the loop with everyone else, including candidates you do not select.

How to use it. Keep this open from the final interview until the last candidate has heard back. Adapt the messages to your own voice.

1. After the decision

- [ ] Decision and reason recorded the same day
- [ ] Selected candidate called by the hiring manager, not just emailed
- [ ] Written offer sent with the details agreed on the call
- [ ] Every other candidate told within the time we promised
- [ ] Interviewers thanked and told the outcome
- [ ] Anything we learned about the process is written down

2. The offer conversation

What I want them to hear	What they will want to know
Why we chose them, in specifics	Role, team, start, compensation, next steps

MESSAGE TO A SELECTED CANDIDATE

Hi [name], thank you for the time and thought you put into every stage. The team has talked it through and we would like to offer you the role of [title]. What stood out for us was [two specifics]. I will call you on [day] to walk through the details, and you will get the written offer straight after. Meanwhile, ask me anything.

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3. Candidates we do not select

This is the part most teams skip, and the part candidates remember. A prompt, kind and specific reply costs a few minutes and protects your reputation for years.

AFTER AN EARLY STAGE

Hi [name], thank you for applying for [title] and for sharing your work. We have decided not to move forward this time. [One specific thing you noticed, if you can share it.] We would be glad to hear from you again for future roles, and if you have any feedback about how we ran the process, I would value it.

AFTER THE FINAL STAGE

Hi [name], thank you for the time you gave us across [stages]. It was a difficult decision, and we have gone with a candidate whose experience matched [specific area] more closely. What impressed us was [specific strength]. I would be glad to give you more detailed feedback on a call if useful, and we would like to stay in touch.

4. What we will share, and when

STAGE THE CANDIDATE REACHED	REPLY WITHIN	WHAT WE SHARE	WHO SENDS IT
After application			
After screening			
After portfolio conversation			
After the craft exercise			
After final conversations			

5. Keeping the door open

How we will keep strong candidates in touch, with their permission

6. Ask every candidate

- [ ] Did you always know what would happen next?
- [ ] Was the time asked of you fair?
- [ ] Did interviewers seem prepared and respectful?
- [ ] What would you change about how we hire?

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PLAYBOOK · PART 3 · ONBOARDING

Onboarding Playbook

From the day an offer is accepted to the end of the first ninety days, so a new designer feels expected, useful and supported.

How to use it. Start it the day the offer is accepted. Share the relevant parts with the new joiner so they can see what is coming.

1. Before day one

WHAT	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
Welcome note from the manager and the team			
Equipment, accounts and access ready			
A buddy chosen and introduced			
First-week schedule shared in advance			
Reading and work to look at, kept light			
Paperwork and HR steps explained			

2. Day one

- [ ] Met at the door, in person or on video, by someone who expected them
- [ ] Workspace and tools working before they sit down
- [ ] Lunch or coffee with the team
- [ ] A short conversation about the first week and what matters most
- [ ] Nothing important left for them to chase

3. The first week

DAY	FOCUS	PEOPLE TO MEET	OUTCOME
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			

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4. The first ninety days

Days 1 to 30: Learn
The people, the product, the way we work. One small contribution.

Days 31 to 60: Contribute
Real work with support. What does good look like?

Days 61 to 90: Own
An area they lead. How we will know it is going well.

Write these with the new joiner in the first week, not for them. A plan they helped write is one they will follow.

5. Check-in prompts for the first month

- [ ] What is clearer than you expected, and what is less clear?
- [ ] Who have you not yet met who you should?
- [ ] What is getting in your way?
- [ ] What would help you do your best work here?
- [ ] What can I do differently as your manager?

6. Close the loop on hiring

At thirty days, ask: what did the hiring process promise that onboarding did not deliver? What would you tell the next person?

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On-site Assignment and Signals Handbook

Design an assignment from the role, say what a strong response contains, and decide the signals you will look for before you meet anyone.

How to use it. Complete sections 2 to 4 for each role you hire, with the hiring manager and one future teammate. Reuse the structure, not the brief.

1. What a good on-site assignment promises

- [ ] The time it takes is stated up front, and it happens in one sitting, on site
- [ ] The problem is shaped like the real job, and no company secrets or free work are being collected
- [ ] The candidate can ask questions and talk to people on the team while they work
- [ ] The candidate owns their work, and it is used only for evaluation
- [ ] Everyone applying for the same role gets the same brief and the same criteria
- [ ] Every candidate gets a reply, and feedback if policy allows

2. Define the challenge from the job role

The core problem this role will own
From the Role Definition Worksheet. What will this person be responsible for solving?

The assignment problem statement
Context, who it is for, the constraint, and what is out of scope. Short enough to read in two minutes.

What the candidate is given and who they can ask
Materials, access to a product manager or engineer, tools, a quiet space

Time and format
Length of the session, how it ends, how long they present

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3. Define the deliverable criteria

Derive these from the problem statement and the role. Write what a strong response contains, and also what you do not need, so nobody is marked down for skipping it.

DELIVERABLE	WHY THIS ROLE NEEDS IT	WHAT STRONG LOOKS LIKE	NOT NEEDED
Problem framing			
Approach and flow			
Decisions and trade-offs			
Communication and walk-through			
Response to critique			

4. Define the signals for the role

A signal is something you can observe that predicts success in this job. Name it, say how it shows up in the room, and decide how you will probe it.

ROLE	SIGNAL	HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THE ROOM	HOW WE PROBE IT
Product designer	Frames the problem before solving it	Asks about users and constraints first, restates the problem in their own words	Change a constraint halfway and watch how they adapt
Researcher	Chooses the method for the question	Explains why this method, what it cannot tell us, and what they would do next	Ask what they would do with half the time
Design systems designer	Thinks in reuse and rules	Finds the pattern behind the screens, defines when not to reuse it	Hand them an edge case the system does not cover
Design lead or manager	Raises the people around them	Draws out the team in the room, handles disagreement openly	Ask how they would give feedback on this very work

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5. Run the session

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS	WHO IS THERE
Before		
Start		
During		
Walk-through		
Close		

6. Record what you saw

SIGNAL	WHAT I SAW OR HEARD	RATING 1 TO 4

What I would want to explore further, and what I would tell the candidate

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WORKSHEET · PART 2 · THE CANDIDATE HIRING EXPERIENCE

Candidate Feedback Survey Worksheet

Ask every candidate how the process felt, define what counts as a positive result before you collect it, and act on what you hear.

How to use it. Decide the questions and the definition of positive first. Send the survey after the outcome is known, to everyone who reached an interview.

1. When and to whom

- [ ] Everyone who reached an interview, whatever the outcome
- [ ] After the decision has been communicated, not before
- [ ] Anonymous, or with a clear promise about who sees the answers
- [ ] Selected candidates again at thirty days, once they have joined

2. Questions

Ask each as a statement on a scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree), then leave room for words.

STATEMENT	WHAT IT TELLS US
I always knew what would happen next and when	Clarity of the process
I was kept informed in good time	Communication and silence
My interviewers were prepared and respectful	Interviewer readiness
The assignment was fair and relevant to the role	Quality of the assessment
The time asked of me was reasonable	Respect for time
I understood what the team is like to work in	Honesty of the story
I would recommend this process to a friend	Overall experience

Open questions: what worked well, what should change, anything we missed

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3. Decide what counts as positive

Our definition of a positive response
For example, a 4 or 5 on the overall question. Write it down before you look at any answers.

How many responses we need before we trust the result
And how we handle small numbers honestly

4. Read the results

QUESTION	POSITIVE RESPONSES	WHAT STOOD OUT	WHAT WE WILL CHANGE

5. Close the loop

- [ ] Shared with HR, interviewers and the hiring manager
- [ ] One change agreed and owned
- [ ] Candidates who raised an issue told what changed, where appropriate
- [ ] Reviewed again after the next completed hire

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WORKSHEET · PART 1 · MANAGING THE HIRING EXPERIENCE

Hiring Experience Tenets Check

Nine tenets to relook at when you redefine a hiring experience. Score where you are, note the evidence and pick your first changes.

How to use it. Score honestly with your HR partner. Any tenet scored 1 or 2 is where to begin.

Score each from 1 (not at all true today) to 4 (consistently true, and we can show it).

TENET	SCORE 1 TO 4	EVIDENCE	FIRST CHANGE
1. We treat hiring as a product with three users: the candidate, the interviewer and the decision-maker			
2. We define the role by the work it will do, not by the nearest engineering title			
3. We write each role fresh, and reuse the process, not the description			
4. We spend human attention where the signal is richest, and do not rely on keywords			
5. We test what the job will actually ask of the person			
6. We define the signals before we meet anyone			
7. We respect time: every ask is proportionate and stated up front			
8. We close every loop: everyone gets a reply and a chance to tell us how it felt			
9. We measure the experience the way we would measure a product			

Where we start

The two or three tenets we will work on first, and who owns each

Come back in three months. A tenet that moved from 2 to 3 with evidence beside it is progress you can show.

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